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Boyhood rituals in an African society

Author(S): Ottenberg, Simon

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In interward contests in the settlement, as well as in intervillage competition, the first match (*ibuzo mgba*, first-wrestle) is often of boys in the unorganized 5–15 years category, pitting two good wrestlers together as a warm-up event. Such contestants frequently display more energy and strength than skill. While boys take great pride in being selected by the men involved on each side to do this, and often become, at a later time, the better village wrestlers, this match is something of a joking affair. Nevertheless, Afikpo males often say that the side that wins this contest will win most of the other events of the day.

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This match is followed by a general wrestling period, *ɔkpughughu* (roughly meaning “group confusion”). Anyone, from the smallest boy of three to a man of thirty years, can wrestle; many youths come out and compete against one another, often at the same time, while the referees comment on their abilities. Old grudges bring about some challenges. A loser gets up and challenges another than the person who defeated him, which he would not do at an organized competition. Among those fifteen years of age and older only the poorer wrestlers appear at this time; the better ones expect to wrestle in the regular matches to follow. There is an air of humor about these preliminary contests. No one takes them seriously, except some of the participants.

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The first organized wrestling grade in Mgbom and many other villages is *mkpufu mgba* (to start off, or to break out-wrestle), made up of boys between the ages of about 15 and 18. In former times this was about the age when

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they joined the adult secret society. At a match between two wards of a village, or between two villages, only the most skillful will be allowed to wrestle; at the lower intercompound level almost every boy tries out. This is the first age at which wrestling contests are taken seriously and boys work hard to improve their abilities. The winner dances around in happiness to the drums. Youths of this age are not well disciplined; they may not wait to be selected by the referees, but break out onto the field in the commons, challenge others to wrestle, and go right to it.

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This is followed by the *isoogu* wrestlers. The term is from *iso*, to grow, and *ogugu*, the growing part of a palm or bamboo tree. The  85 explicit reference is to boys before full maturity who "spread out" (mature); the implicit reference may be to the growth of the penis. This age, often divided into subgroups, includes males of about 18 to 28 years of age, who are usually all members of the adult secret society, and provides the largest number of matches. The side of the winner of the one or two matches between the senior *isoogu* players is considered the winner for the day, even if it loses other matches. But Afikpo also say that there is no official winner for the whole event and that the real interest is in the individual matches. Even young boys watch these contests with excitement and interest.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

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